questioning of the Burmese claim that the McMahon Line represented the international border between the two countries caused concern in Delhi—India, too, claimed that line as demarcating its border with China.[146] A series of border skirmishes in fall 1956 and spring 1957 left officials anxious as well.[147] Nehru worried about the "aggressive way on the part of the Chinese." And it had become evident to him that China could raise the border question "at any time" even though India considered it to be settled.[148]

Until fall 1957, there was talk of potential cooperation. The Indian vice president, Sarvepalli (S.) Radhakrishnan, on a trip to China told Mao that if the two Asian countries worked together, "the world would take note." Despite the "modest" turnout for Radhakrishnan and censoring of his speeches, a diplomat observed that the visit "could not have gone better."[149] Subsequently, however, Nehru noted Mao's unsatisfactory response to the vice president's observation that it was better to change someone's mind in a "friendly way" rather than with suppression.[150]

Then, in September 1957, Delhi received reports from its embassy in Beijing that China had announced the completion of a road connecting Tibet and Xinjiang that seemed to go through Indian territory.[151] There was also a sense that China was delaying some long-agreed-to border negotiations.[152] When they finally occurred in April 1958, in the midst of a general hardening of China's attitude abroad, the talks did not go very well. By June there was a stalemate, and the talks were eventually suspended.[153] Adding to that were concerns about Chinese propaganda in India's northeast, indoctrination of Indian citizens in China, allegations against Indian officials, and the arrest of an Indian embassy employee in Beijing.[154] By declining to stamp Indian-issued passports given to Bhutanese and Sikkimese, China also seemed to be questioning India's special relationship with those kingdoms.[155]

By summer 1958, China's "cooling off" toward India was undeniable to Indian policymakers. The Indian consul general in Shanghai traced it to the "[e]conomic rapprochement" between the US and India, speculations about a Tibet visit by Nehru, and the Chinese sense that the Congress government was losing ground to the communists in India.[156] Nehru believed it was mainly because Beijing suspected India on Tibet.[157]